Joint Attention Is Shared Reference, Not a Language Guarantee

Joint attention is the coordinated processing of one's own attention, another's attention, and a shared referent; associations with later communication are real and not a proof that drilling gaze-following produces language.

DE: MODERATE-CONSTRUCT; LOW-ISOLATED-TRAINING | STATUS: DRAFT | DOMAIN: COGNITION, LANGUAGE | REPLICATION: VERI

WHAT WE KNOW (Narrowest Supported Conclusion)

Before a full theory of other minds, infants process information about their own attention and another person's attention together. Mundy & Newell (2007) describe joint attention as that integrated processing, supported by anterior and posterior attention systems, and as a contributor to later social cognition. Responding to joint attention and initiating it develop on overlapping but different schedules.

EVIDENCE AND CAUSAL ASSESSMENT

Mundy & Newell (2007), Current Directions in Psychological Science, is a theoretical/neural-systems synthesis, not an RCT of joint-attention training in typical samples. It draws on longitudinal and individual-difference work (including Mundy's own programs) showing developmental associations among early attention, joint attention, and later social-cognitive measures. Identification is correlational and experimental in laboratory interaction, not a population trial. Cultural organization of gaze and pointing is not erased by a cortical-network sketch.

EFFECT SIZE AND PERSISTENCE

No portable effect size for "more joint attention" as an intervention in typical development. Associations with later language are informative and not destiny.

BIAS, HETEROGENEITY, AND CONFOUNDING

GI attenuation: n/a (developmental interaction construct, not an observational population phenotype association).

Infant characteristics, caregiver behavior, language environment, and measurement (responding vs initiating) all enter the score. Autism-related joint-attention findings are a clinical literature; they do not describe ordinary missed looks.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT MEAN (Strict Boundary Conditions)

Does not mean a parent must catch every gaze. Does not mean Hart & Risley word counts. Does not mean a missed episode of shared looking is a missed mind. Conversational-turns prediction (Gilkerson) is a different card.

WHAT ACTION IS REASONABLY JUSTIFIED

Ordinary shared looking, pointing, and showing are consistent with the construct. Gaze-following drills as cognitive enhancement are not justified here.

VERIFIED SOURCES & DOI IDENTIFIERS

- Mundy & Newell (2007), Current Directions in Psychological Science (DOI 10.1111/j.1467-8721.2007.00518.x)